Playing with expression

Loud and soft, smooth and short, tempo words and the sustain pedal.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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12. Be Thou My Vision
13. Holy, Holy, Holy

1. Loud and soft

Piano, forte, and everything in between.

Soft-loud

The piano's full name is the **pianoforte**, Italian for "soft-loud". It was the first keyboard that could play both, depending on how firmly you press the keys.

Music marks loudness with Italian letters called **dynamics**: ***p*** (piano) means soft and ***f*** (forte) means loud. A mark stays in force until the next one.

Loud doesn't mean banging. Let the weight of your arm sink into the key. For soft, use less weight but still press all the way down.

The whole family

From softest to loudest:

pp pianissimo, very soft · ***p*** piano, soft · ***mp*** mezzo-piano, medium soft · ***mf*** mezzo-forte, medium loud · ***f*** forte, loud · ***ff*** fortissimo, very loud

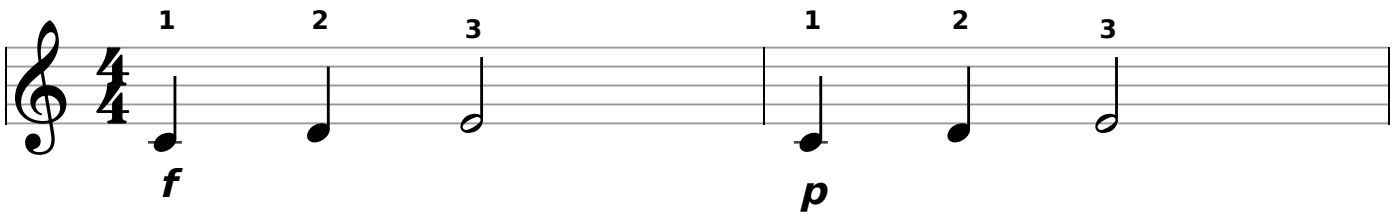
"Mezzo" means "half". If a piece has no dynamics at all, play it about ***mf***.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is the second half louder or softer than the first?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Softer It starts forte and the answer comes back piano, like an echo.

> **Review**
>
> What does mf mean?
>
> **Answer:** Medium loud mf is mezzo-forte: half loud, or medium loud.

Practise · Echo game

Play each phrase forte, then echo it piano. With listening on, I'll tell you whether I could hear the difference.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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2. Getting louder and softer

Crescendo and diminuendo: shaping a line.

Little by little

Crescendo (*cresc.*) means get louder little by little. **Diminuendo** (*dim.*) means get softer little by little. Sometimes they're drawn as long thin wedges called hairpins: opening for louder, closing for softer.

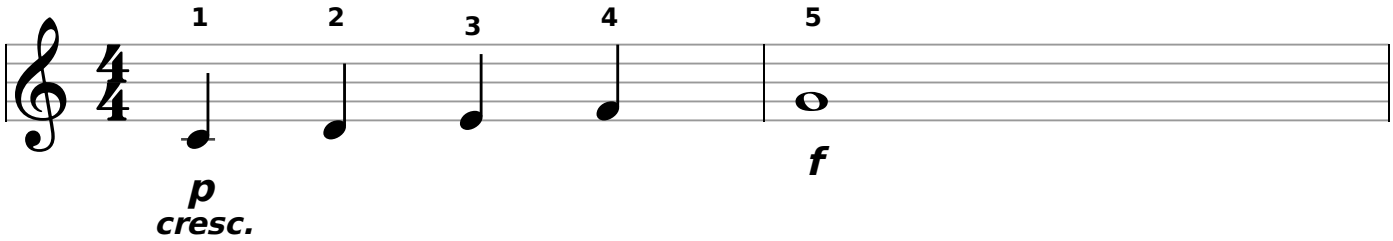
The secret is to **plan the journey**. Start a crescendo soft enough that you have somewhere to go.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Does this get louder or softer?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Louder (crescendo) It starts piano and grows to fortissimo: a crescendo.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Softer (diminuendo) It fades from very loud to very soft: a diminuendo.

Practise · Up the hill and down again

Grow louder as you climb to G, then fade away as you come back down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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3. Jacob's Ladder

A spiritual that grows louder as it climbs.

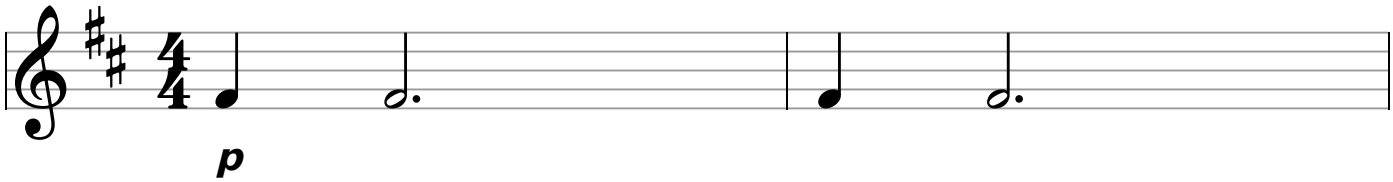
Climbing the ladder

We Are Climbing Jacob's Ladder is a spiritual whose tune climbs like its words: F♯ to A, E to B, then up to the high D.

Start **piano**, make a **crescendo** as it climbs, reach **forte** at the top, then **diminuendo** on the way down.

Practise · Jacob's Ladder

Soft, growing, loud, then fading away.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

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4. Smooth and detached

Legato and staccato: two kinds of touch.

Legato and staccato

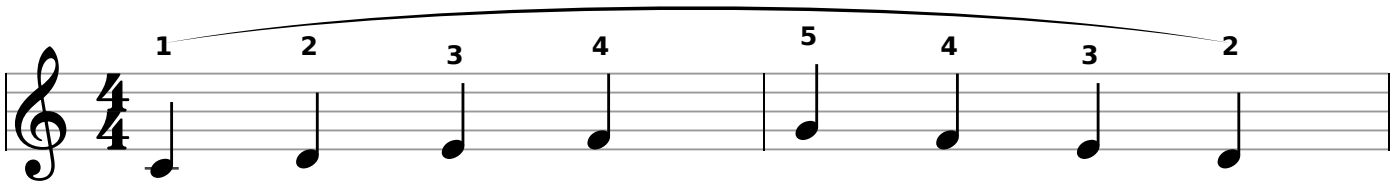
Legato means smooth and connected: hold each note until the very moment the next one sounds, so there's no gap. A curved line over several notes, called a **slur**, asks for legato.

Staccato means short and detached. A **dot** above or below the note head tells you to let go quickly, as if the key were hot. The note still gets its full beat; the rest of the beat is silence.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Smooth (legato) or detached (staccato)?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Staccato Each note is short, with a little silence after it: staccato.

Practise · Legato

Make it smooth: don't lift one finger until the next one goes down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Staccato

Bounce off each key. Small, light movements from the wrist.

Practise · Both touches

Smooth, then short. With listening on, I'll tell you if your staccato notes sounded crisp.

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5. Go, Tell It on the Mountain

A joyful spiritual with some detached notes.

Legato and staccato together

Go, Tell It on the Mountain is a Christmas spiritual. Play it **forte** and joyful. Most of it is smooth, but "over the hills" and "Jesus" have **staccato** dots: make them short and bouncy.

Practise · Go, Tell It on the Mountain

Loud and happy. Bounce the staccato notes.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

6. Slurs and phrases

Playing a melody like a singer breathes.

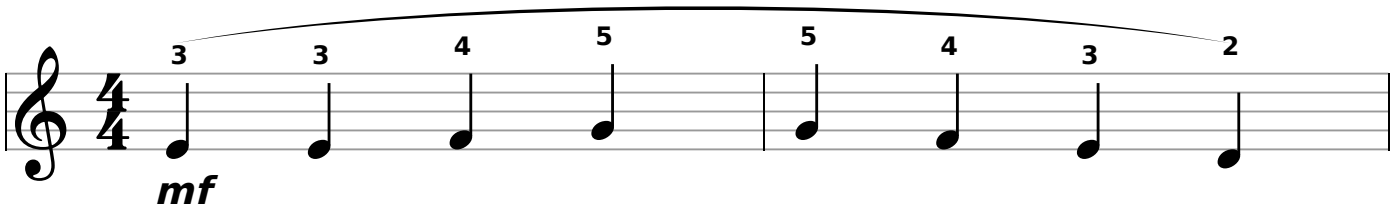
Musical sentences

Melodies are made of **phrases**, like sentences in speech. A phrase is usually two or four bars long, and a long slur often shows where it begins and ends.

Shape each phrase: lean a little towards its high point, then relax at the end. Between phrases, lift your hand gently, like a singer taking a breath.

Practise · Ode to Joy, with phrasing

Two phrases: the first mezzo-forte, the second piano like an answer. Breathe between them.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

7. Doxology with expression

Phrases, a quiet third line, and a strong ending.

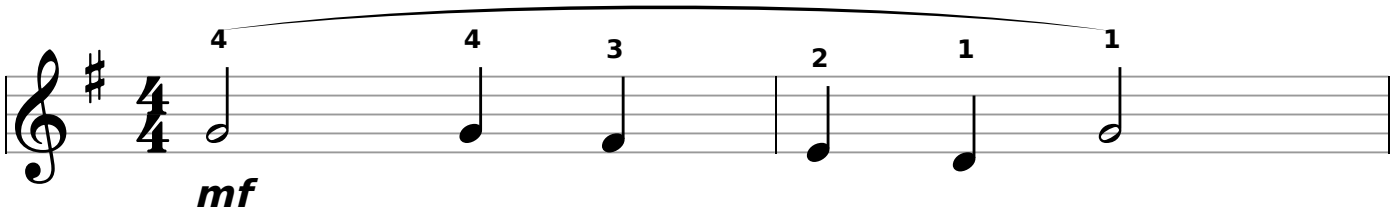
Singing it on the piano

Each line of the Doxology is one **phrase**, one breath for a singer. Shape each one with a slur, and lift gently between them.

Play the first two lines **mezzo-forte**. Make the third line **piano**, growing louder at its end, so the last line, "Praise Father, Son, and Holy Ghost", can ring out **forte**.

Practise · The Doxology, shaped

Mezzo-forte, mezzo-forte, piano getting louder, then forte. Breathe between the lines.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

8. Fairest Lord Jesus

A hymn tune shaped in six phrases.

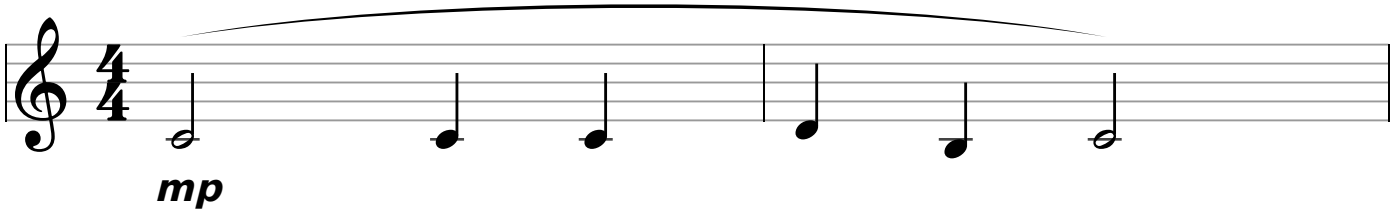
Six phrases

Fairest Lord Jesus is sung to a Silesian folk tune first printed in 1842. Each slur is one line of the hymn: play it smoothly, then lift gently before the next.

The third phrase climbs to the high C and grows a little louder. The last phrase starts mezzo-forte and fades away.

Practise · Fairest Lord Jesus

One breath per slur. Lift between them.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

9. Tempo words

Adagio, Andante, Moderato, Allegro.

How fast?

At the top of a piece you'll often find an Italian word for the **tempo**, the speed of the beat:

Adagio: slow and calm · **Andante**: at a walking pace · **Moderato**: moderate · **Allegro**: quick and cheerful

Some music also gives a number, like ♩ = 80, which means 80 beats per minute. You can set that on the metronome in Daily practice.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which tempo is this?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Adagio (slow) Slow and calm: Adagio.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Allegro (quick) Quick and bright: Allegro.

> **Review**
>
> Andante means...
>
> **Answer:** At a walking pace Andante comes from the Italian for "walking".

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10. The sustain pedal

What the right pedal does, and how it's written.

The right pedal

The pedal on the right is the **sustain pedal**. While it's down, notes keep ringing after you let go of the keys. It makes the sound warm and full.

Music shows it with **Ped.** where you press down and * where you lift. Too much pedal blurs everything together, so lift whenever the harmony changes.

Press it with your right heel resting on the floor. If you're playing on a keyboard, a plug-in sustain pedal is worth having later on.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is the pedal down?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Yes, the notes blend and ring on The notes keep ringing and blend together: that's the sustain pedal.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this time?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** No, each note stops when released Each note stops cleanly: no pedal.

> **Review**
>
> What does * mean under the music?
>
> **Answer:** Lift the pedal Ped. means press down; * means lift.

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11. All Through the Night

A Welsh lullaby with the sustain pedal.

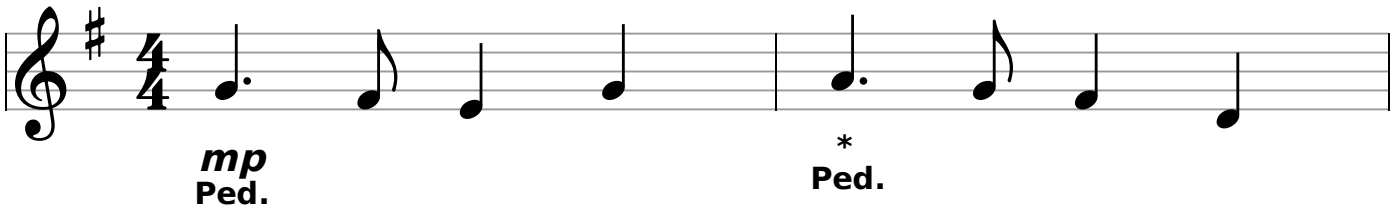
Pedal in every bar

Ar Hyd y Nos ("All Through the Night") is a Welsh folk melody, first printed in 1784. Play it gently with the **sustain pedal**.

Change the pedal at the start of every bar: lift, then press again straight away. That keeps the sound warm without blurring.

Practise · All Through the Night

Softly. Lift and press the pedal at every bar line.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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12. Be Thou My Vision

An old Irish melody to shape with soft and loud.

Be Thou My Vision

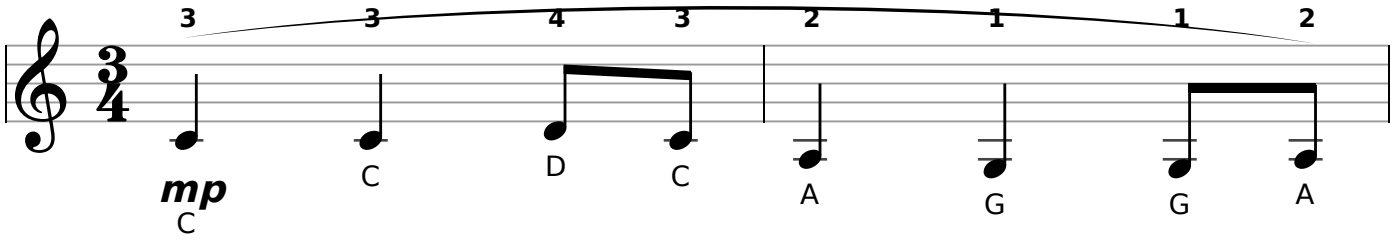
This tune, called **Slane**, is an Irish folk melody. It was paired with an ancient Irish prayer in the early 1900s and is now sung all over the world.

Use what you've learned in this unit: begin ***mp***, grow through the second line, sing out ***f*** at the top ("High King of heaven"), then let it settle back to ***p***. Keep every phrase **legato** under its slur.

It's in 3/4 and ranges from low G to high C, so your hand moves a few times. Follow the finger numbers.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2 (3/4)

"Be Thou my vision, O Lord of my heart; naught be all else to me, save that Thou art."



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4 (3/4)

"Thou my best thought, by day or by night, waking or sleeping, Thy presence my light."

Practise · Dress rehearsal (3/4)

The whole hymn, with hints. Listen to the demo first to hear the dynamics.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

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13. Holy, Holy, Holy

A grand hymn in D major, from forte to fortissimo.

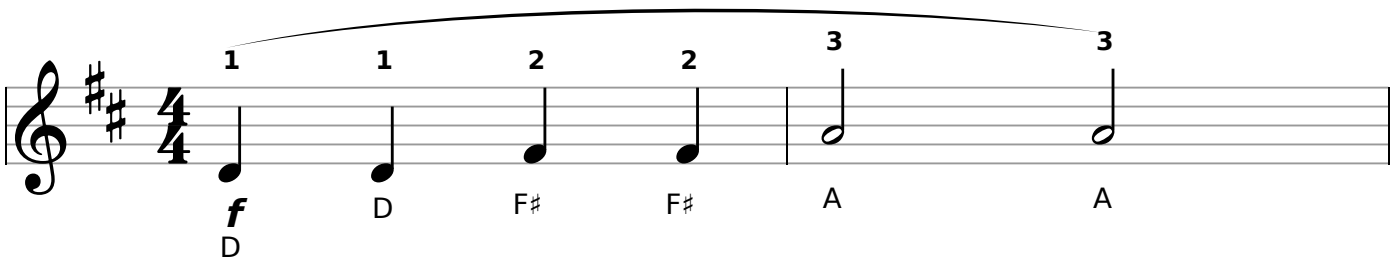
Holy, Holy, Holy

John Bacchus Dykes wrote this tune, **Nicaea**, in 1861 for Reginald Heber's words. It's one of the most majestic hymns there is.

It's in **D major**, so every F and C is sharp, just like your D position. Play the opening ***f***, drop to ***mp*** for "Early in the morning", build back up, and save your biggest sound, ***ff***, for the high D near the end.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2 [D]

"Holy, holy, holy! Lord God Almighty! Early in the morning our song shall rise to Thee."



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4 [D]

"Holy, holy, holy! Merciful and mighty! God in three Persons, blessed Trinity!"

Practise · Dress rehearsal [D]

The whole hymn, with hints. Make the dynamics big and clear.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Show a clear difference between soft and loud playing.
- ☐ Shape a crescendo, diminuendo, and musical phrase.
- ☐ Make legato and staccato sound different.
- ☐ Choose an appropriate tempo and change the pedal cleanly where taught.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
